

WAR CORRESPONDENT PHILOSOPHY

Method, Evidence, and the Ethics of Research Under a Closing Window

A Six-Volume Manuscript Series

VOLUME V

Mechanism Transfer and Domain Portability: When a Formal Structure Survives Its Crossing Into a New Domain

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ABOUT THIS SERIES

A research programme develops its own working methods long before anyone states them as a method. Between 2026 and the present, an independent research programme on longevity, institutions, and artificial intelligence produced its results by a specific practice: writing from inside the events under analysis, in sustained collaboration with a large language model, while withholding prescriptive conclusions and stating in advance what would count as evidence against its own claims.

War Correspondent Philosophy names, tests, and states the falsification conditions for that practice. Across six volumes, the series treats the practice itself as an object of study: what proximity to an unfolding event can and cannot license, what a researcher owes a claim before treating it as safe from revision, why a sequence of dated publications can carry evidential weight a single publication cannot, what changes when part of the cognitive labor is performed by an instrument with no memory of its own prior contributions, when a formal mechanism identified in one domain is genuinely present in another rather than merely resembling it, and what a framework is obligated to do with itself once part of it has been shown false.

This series does not defend the substantive conclusions of the research programme it examines. It asks whether the programme followed the method it claims to follow, and specifies the terms on which that claim could be shown wrong.

The question running through all six volumes:

What obligations bind a researcher who writes from inside the events a research programme analyzes, in collaboration with an instrument that is itself part of the event?

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- I. The Embedded Witness: Temporal Proximity, Designed Absence, and the Self-Demonstrating Text
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- VI. The Prospective and Self-Revising Life of a Framework: What a Theory Does After It Is Falsified

Mechanism Transfer and Domain Portability: When a Formal Structure Survives Its Crossing Into a New Domain

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Two things that look alike can look alike for at least three different reasons: shared origin, independent arrival at the same form, or superficial resemblance that dissolves under scrutiny. A research programme that repeatedly moves a formal mechanism from one domain into an unrelated one needs a way to distinguish these cases, or every cross-domain claim it makes is vulnerable to the objection that the resemblance was rhetorical rather than structural. This essay describes a demanding standard for a genuine transfer, developed and applied to a case in which an evolutionary mechanism is proposed to operate literally, rather than by analogy, in the history of a regional institution. The standard requires a domain to literally satisfy the formal preconditions of the mechanism in question — a population of entities, a process that transmits structure between generations with reasonable fidelity, and variation that causes some entities to persist and others not to — rather than merely resembling a domain where the mechanism is already accepted. It requires identifying with precision which entity plays which structural role, since a transferred mechanism does not automatically come with its components pre-labeled. And it prefers a specific, counterintuitive kind of evidence: two systems that arrive at the same structure with no shared history between them provide stronger confirmation that the structure is doing real explanatory work than two systems that share the structure because they share an ancestor, since independent origin rules out inheritance as the explanation in a way shared descent cannot — though, as the essay's closing sections make clear, the biological version of this test is considerably cleaner than any institutional application of it can claim to be. Applying the standard to a specific historical case shows it capable of explaining a data pattern that a cruder transfer could only redescribe, by revealing two genuinely distinct underlying strategies where a flatter comparison saw only inconsistent measurement. The same rigor, applied honestly, can also show a historically successful strategy falling short by orders of magnitude of what a harder version of the same problem would require — a sober finding a careless transfer would be more likely to paper over than to state.

Keywords: mechanism transfer; generalized Darwinism; replicator; interactor; homology; convergent evolution; r/K selection; metapopulation; War Correspondent Philosophy

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1 Introduction

Two things that look alike can look alike for at least three different reasons, and telling them apart matters enormously for what the resemblance is allowed to prove. They might share a common origin, so the resemblance is inherited rather than independently arrived at. They might have reached the same form independently, for reasons that have nothing to do with shared history, in which case the resemblance is evidence that something about the form itself is doing real work. Or they might simply resemble each other in a handful of surface respects while differing in everything that actually matters, in which case the resemblance proves nothing and the comparison was never more than a metaphor. A research programme that repeatedly moves a formal mechanism identified in one domain into an entirely different one — biology into institutional history, in the case this volume examines — needs a way to tell these three cases apart, or every cross-domain claim it makes is vulnerable to the same objection: that the mechanism does not actually transfer, and the resemblance was rhetorical.

2 A Claim About Domain-Independence

Geoffrey Hodgson and Thorbjørn Knudsen's account of generalized Darwinism supplies a demanding standard for what would make a transfer more than rhetorical. They argue that variation, a mechanism of inheritance that transmits traits between generations with reasonable fidelity, and selection produced by that variation causing differential persistence are jointly necessary and sufficient conditions for a Darwinian explanation, and that these conditions are domain-independent: wherever a population of entities literally varies, some mechanism literally transmits structure between generations, and that variation literally causes some entities to persist and others not to, a Darwinian explanation literally applies — not as a suggestive analogy borrowed from biology, but as the same explanatory structure biology happens to be where the pattern was first described (Hodgson & Knudsen, 2010). The claim is demanding because it is falsifiable in a specific way: a domain either does or does not contain a population, a fidelity-preserving transmission mechanism, and variation-driven differential persistence, and if it does not, invoking evolutionary language about that domain is exactly the empty metaphor the standard exists to rule out.

3 Two Ways to Preserve a Structure

Testing whether a domain literally satisfies the standard requires knowing precisely what is doing the transmitting and what is doing the interacting with the environment, a distinction the biologist and philosopher David Hull formalized as the difference between a replicator, the unit that passes on structure with reasonable fidelity, and an interactor, the unit that engages the environment as a cohesive whole and whose success or failure in that engagement makes replication differential (Hull, 1988). In the biological case these are usually easy to separate: genes replicate, organisms interact with the world and live or die. In an institutional case the separation takes real analytical work. A template — a specific configuration of frontier defense doctrine, fiscal administration, and a protocol for absorbing displaced elites, say — can function as a replicator: a structure capable of being reconstructed with reasonable fidelity long after the specific regime that last used it has disappeared, dormant for centuries with no interactor expressing it at all, and re-expressed as a new interactor — a

new regime, built by different people, in a different generation — whenever the environmental condition that originally selected for the template recurs. Establishing that a replicator persisted through a genuine gap in interactor expression, and was reconstructed rather than merely resembled by coincidence when the environment recurred, is what separates a literal claim about institutional inheritance from a loose metaphor about history repeating itself.

4 The Test That Actually Discriminates

Even a genuine replicator-interactor relationship leaves an ambiguity a careful transfer has to resolve: entities that share a profile of traits might share it because they share a common replicator, which biologists call homology, or because they arrived at the same profile independently, from different starting points, with no shared history at all, which they call convergence. This distinction supplies a more discriminating test than resemblance alone, and in a direction that is not obvious in advance: convergence is the stronger evidence, not the weaker one. Two interactors that share a profile because they share a replicator have not independently confirmed that the profile does real adaptive work; they have inherited the same structure, and their agreement is one data point wearing the appearance of two. Two interactors with no shared history at all, arriving at the same profile from entirely separate starting conditions, cannot be explained by inheritance, which leaves the shared environmental pressure, and whatever the profile does in response to it, as the only remaining explanation available. A set of institutions descended from one common template, compared against one another, tests whether the template was faithfully copied. A set of institutions with no common ancestor at all, compared against one another, tests whether a particular structure is independently adaptive under a particular kind of pressure — a stronger and more informative test, precisely because independent origin removes the explanation a shared ancestor would otherwise supply for free.

The standard is easier to apply in biology than the transfer to institutions might suggest, and the difference is worth naming rather than passing over. Common ancestry in the biological case is a comparatively clean, checkable condition, because genetic inheritance is close to the only channel through which trait information moves between lineages; two lineages either share a genetic ancestor or they do not, and the question is normally decidable in principle even when it is hard to decide in practice. Institutions have no equivalent clean channel. A template can travel between two states that share no political lineage at all through trade, conquest, translated administrative texts, or diplomatic observation, producing a real category the biological binary has no slot for: partial, documented cultural influence well short of the direct institutional inheritance a true replicator relationship requires, but well short of true independence too. Ruling out this middle case is a harder empirical burden in an institutional application than ruling out shared ancestry ordinarily is in a biological one, and treating the two as equally clean would overstate what the institutional version of the test can deliver.

5 Same Mechanism, Different Strategies

A further precision keeps a genuine mechanism transfer from collapsing two distinct patterns into one. Ecological theory distinguishes K-selected strategies, which invest heavily in a small number of long-lived individuals optimized to endure, from r-selected strategies, which favor rapid turnover and recolonization, with persistence maintained at the level of the population rather than any single long-lived member of it (MacArthur & Wilson, 1967). Applied to institutions facing a recurring disruption, this distinction explains rather than merely redescribes a pattern that would otherwise look like measurement inconsistency: two institutions can respond to a structurally similar threat with genuinely different, sometimes

competing strategies — one investing enormous resources into a single enduring interactor, the other tolerating the repeated extinction of individual interactors so long as the replicator survives to be re-expressed — and a measurement that ranks them inconsistently across different metrics may not be measuring the same thing badly. It may be correctly detecting two different quantities. Richard Levins's condition for the persistence of a population distributed across a shifting patchwork of local sites — that the rate of recolonizing empty sites exceed the rate at which occupied sites go locally extinct — gives the r-selected strategy a precise, checkable requirement of its own (Levins, 1969), distinct from whatever requirement governs the K-selected alternative, rather than a vaguer sense that persistence is somehow good.

6 What a Genuine Transfer Still Doesn't Give You

Confirming that a mechanism genuinely transfers is not the same as confirming that a historically successful response transfers with it, and the distinction matters most exactly where it is most tempting to blur. A domain can satisfy every formal condition for a given evolutionary strategy, and historical instances of that strategy can be real, literal, non-metaphorical successes, without those successes being large enough in magnitude to meet a substantially larger version of the same challenge. Measuring a historically realized recolonization rate against the rate a new and more demanding disruption regime would require can show a strategy working exactly as the theory predicts while still falling short by orders of magnitude of what a harder problem would now need — a finding a mechanism transfer is positioned to state with some precision, and a more useful thing for it to establish than a reassuring but unearned conclusion that history has already solved the harder problem too.

7 What This Doesn't Settle

This volume has described what distinguishes a mechanism transfer that is genuine from one that is merely evocative: literal satisfaction of a domain-independent standard, a precise account of what plays the replicator role and what plays the interactor role, a preference for convergent over inherited evidence tempered by an honest accounting of how much harder that preference is to apply outside biology, and enough strategic precision to avoid mistaking two different quantities for one badly measured quantity. It has not addressed what a framework built this carefully is obligated to do with itself once one of its own components is shown to have failed — including a component, like the strategic shortfall this volume's own closing section identifies, that a transfer this rigorous can reveal to be insufficient rather than successful. That is the subject of the volume that closes this series.

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